

THE FIVE, AS PEOPLE

Fable, v1.0, 2026-08-29. Written blind: Fable was not told who did it.

Nell Casey

Nell Casey was forty-four and painted letters for a living. Shop fronts, boat names, the menu boards outside the harbour cafés, and once, for a bet, the side of a bus. She had a unit behind the fish market with a kettle, a radio that only got one station, and a ladder she would not let anyone else climb. On the morning she died the old Regent cinema had three of its six letters back, and the ladder was still chained to the railing under them.

She swam off the slip most mornings from April to November and told people it was for her back. It was for the quiet. She ate standing up, fried egg on white, and kept her cash in a Quality Street tin because she distrusted the bank and, more than that, invoicing. She was owed money all over town and forgot nobody who owed it. She read the last page of a book first. She smoked two cigarettes a day behind the unit and lied about it with total confidence.

She was funny in a way that cost you something: she ranked people's handwriting out loud and told you the truth about your kitchen. She was halfway through a thing with the council about parking, a thing with her sister about their mother's house, and a thing with the cinema owner about the colour of the R. None of it is finished. That is how you know she was there.

Owen Pask

Owen Pask, forty-six, runs the crane at the boatyard and has known Nell since they were eleven and shared a school bus. He is the only one of the four who met her mother, which means he is the only one who knows what Nell was like before she was good at anything: loud, badly dressed, in trouble. He drove her to the hospital the night her mother went in for the last time. He never mentions it, she never thanked him, and that was the arrangement. He started swimming off the slip because she did and has hated it every morning since. On a Tuesday he came to the unit at half twelve, ate whatever she was eating, and said nothing for twenty minutes. She called it his visit.

Frightened, Owen gets tidy. He cleans tools that are already clean. He writes lists and loses them. He goes very reasonable, which is worse than shouting, because you can hear him deciding what not to say.

He thinks Margo is sound, if cold, and would trust her with paper. He thinks Bram is a kid Nell collected, and that she would have got bored of him. He has never liked Sian. He thinks her kindness is a way of being in charge, he has thought it for twelve years, and he knows she knows.

Sian Reddy

Sian Reddy, thirty-nine, is the practice nurse at the surgery on Wharf Street and joined the slip swimmers nine years ago because a patient said it helped. Nell told her she swam like someone being chased. They were friends by August. On a Tuesday Sian would text at six to say she wasn't coming and then come, and they would sit in the car with the heater on, arguing about whether Sian's husband should be told a thing. Sian is

the one Nell rang at four in the morning, once, three years ago. Sian drove over. They never talked about what was said, and when Sian tried, Nell changed the subject so fast it was like a door closing.

Frightened, Sian talks. She fills the room, allocates jobs, makes tea nobody asked for. Underneath it she is counting exits. She reads bodies for a living and can tell a lie from the neck, and she has stopped trusting that since Nell died, because she stood in that kitchen a hundred times and saw nothing.

She loves Bram without quite respecting him. She finds Margo hard work and honest. She has never liked Owen. She thinks his silence is a performance, and that Nell fell for it for thirty years.

Margo Lisk

Margo Lisk, fifty-three, does the accounts for half the businesses on the harbour and did Nell's for free, which Nell resented. They met when Nell lettered the office door and undercharged, and Margo posted a cheque for the difference with a note that said "don't be a martyr". That was fourteen years ago. Margo does not swim. She stands on the slip with a flask and has never once got in. On a Tuesday she left a bag of receipts on the counter at the unit, and on Friday she collected it unopened, and this was a joke neither of them found funny any more. Margo is the one who knew about the money. Nell had more than anyone would guess, and Margo knows where it came from, and it was not from painting letters. She has not told the other three and does not intend to.

Frightened, Margo gets sharp. She says the true thing in the worst way. She has made Sian cry twice since the funeral and apologised once. She sleeps badly and does sums at three in the morning that come out the same every time.

She rates Owen. She finds Sian exhausting and right about most things. She has never liked Bram. She thinks he was Nell's project, and that projects end.

Bram Tolley

Bram Tolley, thirty-four, teaches design at the secondary school and turned up at the unit seven years ago asking Nell to teach him signwriting. She refused, then did it anyway, Tuesday evenings, for money at first and then for nothing. He is the only one who can do her hand. When she was behind she sent him up the ladder she would not let anyone climb. He swims badly and only in summer and she never let him hear the end of it. He is also the only one she talked to about the other three. He knows what she thought of Owen's silences, Sian's tea and Margo's cheques, and it is not what any of them would want to hear. He has told nobody, partly out of loyalty and partly because it would make him look like what Margo says he is.

Frightened, Bram jokes. Then he drinks. Then he goes still in a way that is not calm, and if you speak to him then he will answer a question you didn't ask.

He likes Margo, which she does not believe. He thinks Sian is the best of them and the easiest to lie to. He has never known what to do with Owen, who looks at him the way a man reads the bottom of an invoice, and he has stopped trying.

The two lines

Room: Owen and Sian. Each has decided the other is acting, and between them they hold the earliest thing and the most private thing anyone knew about her, and neither would believe the other's version.

Keep: The two cigarettes a day. She lied about them to everyone, all four of them knew, and each of the four believed they were the only one who did.